

Responding to Student Writing: The Labor Question

A Reader for Graduate Teaching Associates

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Dear Colleagues,

The following readings are designed to help you think about how to manage the responding load that every teacher of composition must engage. We learn by doing—that’s my first principle of teaching writing—and so the best way for a student to improve is by doing the work. The writing teacher’s role, as I see it, is to show English 101 students what having a genuine reader of their writing means. They know what it means to have a grader of their writing: they’ve had that for twelve years of schooling. The most important work a teacher can do is to help show them how to get from what they’ve written to what a reader needs and wants. That’s challenging work, and it doesn’t happen in one paper, or even one semester. It happens slowly, one piece of writing at a time. Beyond the approaches and perspectives in the accompanying reading, I’ll offer some tips that have worked for me.

1. Read the whole thing first. Pen down. You’re not a grader first; you’re a reader first, showing a student the grace and curiosity and engagement their writing deserves.
2. Never, ever mix late-stage editing and proofreading feedback with early-stage argument and organization feedback. Don’t bother correcting a misspelling when the paragraph itself will be overhauled.
3. Limit your comments. A student will not respond to every suggestion you make, and they should not: that makes it your paper, not theirs. Help them with what’s most important.
4. Students revise before you get eyes on it. Use peer review in conjunction with your assignment’s criteria; have other students assess, using your list of criteria, whether the student’s submission meets the criteria; if it doesn’t, they revise before you see it. Students will *want* what they see as “the answer” from the instructor, but they’ll *learn* from other students who are trying to complete the same task.
5. Have criteria for peer review. Ask peer review groups to assess drafts on the same qualities and criteria you’ll be grading them on—and, as in tip 2, ask peer reviewers to assess *different* criteria based upon the stage the drafts are at. Don’t ask peer reviewers to look at punctuation if the draft’s focus is on supporting evidence.
6. Batch and time your responses. Responding is work, and the work’s quality depends in part on the worker’s capacity. If I respond to more than five or six pieces of writing in a stretch, my mind gets fuzzy and the quality of my guidance declines. For me, a twenty-minute timer and batches of four papers at a stretch, then a break, works well. If you start responding the day the papers come in and handle two batches a day, one in the morning and one in the evening, the load can feel more manageable.

The challenge you face is the same challenge every composition teacher has faced for over a hundred years, as the accompanying readings indicate. It’s a tough challenge, and it’s profoundly shaped composition’s discourse and scholarship. As a labor relation, the work of responding to student writing can sometimes feel thankless or unfair. One reward, which may begin to balance at least the feeling of the cost, is the opportunity to read the writing of somebody who’s done what you asked, and in doing so to show them the grace and understanding of a genuine human reader who values their work. That reward is real, but it doesn’t settle the account: the cost is set by choices about section size and course load that are made above the classroom, and those choices can be changed.

Contents

1. Coon, Arthur M. “An Economic X Marks the Spot.” *College English*, vol. 9, no. 1, 1947, pp. 25–31.

In a dialogue between a New Instructor who has timed himself at half an hour per theme and an Old Hand who adds up his week to sixty-one hours, Coon arrives at a budget of about five minutes a theme: mark only “Sp” and “Ref” and write one closing comment. He then argues the real problem is overload and proposes sections of twenty to twenty-five, with no more than three sections per teacher. The first lesson for a new TA: do the arithmetic of your own week before deciding how long a paper deserves.

2. Hopkins, Edwin M. "Can Good Composition Teaching Be Done under Present Conditions?" *The English Journal*, vol. 1, no. 1, 1912, pp. 1–8.

The first article in the journal's first issue answers its title in one word: "No." Hopkins treats composition as a laboratory subject whose only apparatus is the teacher's time, and argues that schools pay for about 40 percent of the instruction it requires, leaving teachers to supply the rest at their own expense. He offers no technique; what he offers TAs is a way to see an impossible load as a fact about the institution rather than a personal failure.

3. Popken, Randall. "Edwin Hopkins and the Costly Labor of Composition Teaching." *College Composition and Communication*, vol. 55, no. 4, 2004, pp. 618–41.

Drawing on Hopkins's journals and letters, Popken shows him reading student papers three to four hours a day and hospitalized from exhaustion by 1919, while his campus and national campaigns to reduce loads failed. His survey found an average load of 104 students against a workable ceiling of about 61. For conscientious new teachers it is a cautionary mirror: personal devotion does not solve a structural problem.

4. Connors, Robert J. "Overwork/Underpay: Labor and Status of Composition Teachers since 1880." *Rhetoric Review*, vol. 9, no. 1, 1990, pp. 108–26.

Connors explains how responding became composition's defining labor. Rhetoric moved from oral forms that scaled to a written pedagogy that doesn't, enrollments exploded, and the work settled onto TAs, instructors, and disproportionately women, at a fraction of professors' pay. For TAs, the essay gives their paper load a history and names an institutional remedy: extra teaching credit for those who teach writing.

5. Sommers, Nancy. "Responding to Student Writing." *College Composition and Communication*, vol. 33, no. 2, 1982, pp. 148–56.

Sommers estimates 20 to 40 minutes per paper, then shows that most of that time is poorly spent: comments take over the student's text, mix editing commands with calls to develop ideas, and are generic enough to fit any paper. Her remedy is to fit comments to the draft's stage. For TAs, the time-saving lesson is direct: stop correcting errors on first drafts, since much of that text will be cut anyway.

6. Elbow, Peter. "High Stakes and Low Stakes in Assigning and Responding to Writing." *New Directions for Teaching and Learning*, no. 69, 1997, pp. 5–13.

Elbow matches high- and low-stakes assignments to a range of response, from none at all through straight and wavy lines, praise, and description up to full critical response, which he argues teachers should use far less. His suggestions are built for commenting late at night and in a hurry: read the whole paper first, criticize only two or three problems, and give full feedback on a draft but only a quick verdict on the revision. He also gives TAs explicit permission: assigning writing you don't comment on is still teaching.

7. Haswell, Richard H. "Minimal Marking." *College English*, vol. 45, no. 6, 1983, pp. 600–04.

Haswell wrote this just after stepping down as WSU's director of composition, as a method he recommended to TAs: mark each surface error only with a check in the margin, and have students find and fix the errors themselves before the grade is recorded. Students caught 60 to 70 percent on their own, and Haswell saved about four minutes a paper while error rates fell by half over a semester. He suggests the same "minimal functional mark" could serve for larger problems.

8. Haswell, Richard. "The Complexities of Responding to Student Writing; or, Looking for Shortcuts via the Road of Excess." *Across the Disciplines*, vol. 3, 2006, doi:10.37514/ATD-J.2006.3.1.02.

Twenty-three years later, Haswell tests his own shortcut against the research, asking which shortcuts save teacher time without shortchanging students. His directions include discipline-specific model papers, a "Redo" line where a paper falls below standard, ten-minute read-aloud conferences, and above all limiting advice to one or two things the student can do. He calls this responder "craft wise," and concedes that response stays laborious, which is "what we are paid to do."

Further Reading

Hesford, Wendy S., Adela C. Licona, and Christa Teston, eds. *Precarious Rhetorics*.

Horner, Bruce. *Terms of Work for Composition: A Materialist Critique*.

Inoue, Asao. *Labor-Based Grading Contracts: Building Equity and Inclusion in the Compassionate Writing Classroom*.

Ohmann, Richard. *English in America: A Radical View of the Profession*.

Strickland, Donna. *The Managerial Unconscious in the History of Composition Studies*.

Watkins, Evan. *Work Time: English Departments and the Circulation of Cultural Value*.